

An Autistic Child in Your Coaching / Activity

For sports coaches, PE teachers & activity leaders — supporting an autistic primary-school child (roughly ages 6–11).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a child's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Sport settings are often loud, unpredictable and socially demanding — which is why autistic children are, on average, **less active than peers**, not from lack of interest but from barriers in the environment. Resistance at change-over is **inertia** (changing track costs energy), not defiance. The research is clear on what helps: predictable routines, sensory-friendly spaces, good relationships and a strengths-based, game-based approach. Reframe success — the goal at this age is a child who **wants to come back next week**.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Won't start, stop or switch drills; "defiant"	Autistic inertia — changing track costs real energy
Meltdown or withdrawal at the whistle or in the hall	Sensory overload from noise, echoes, lights — involuntary
Deeply absorbed in one skill or routine	Single-focus strength — let them stay with it
Doesn't notice thirst, overheating or a scrape	Interoception differences when absorbed
Takes coaching literally; needs a moment to answer	Literal, single-channel communication + processing time

Try this

- **Predictable warm-up and cool-down every session** as transition ramps; warn before switching drills.
- **Show, then say** — visual demonstration beats a speech; **one instruction at a time** in clear language.
- **Reduce sudden sound** (hand signals, quiet claps), allow ear-defenders and soft kit; warn before a whistle.
- **Schedule, specific drink and rest breaks** — check in ("water now — yes, you!") since the child may not flag thirst.
- **Offer choice and a defined role** (scorekeeper, warm-up leader) — control lowers anxiety; celebrate effort and the interest.
- **Have a plan for overload**: an agreed quiet corner and a signal to step out.

Avoid this

- Surprise changes, last-minute fixture switches, or forcing group pair-work without prep.
- Punishing or publicly stopping stimming and movement.
- Reading a freeze/shutdown as "not trying" or defiance.

When to get more support

Individual sports (swimming, running, martial arts, climbing, athletics) often suit monotropic kids — fewer simultaneous social channels, clear structure, room for deep focus. Team sports can work beautifully *if* the social load is managed (clear roles, supportive teammates). Talk with the parent about triggers and what regulates the child.

If the child is a girl

Girls camouflage heavily and may be missed; the quiet, compliant child may be running on empty. Watch for withdrawal and check in gently.

About this guide

AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 4, sports & coaching), the **Family guide** (Part 3) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual child.

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Michaud & Harvey (2025, physical-activity scoping review); Dwyer (2025). Full citations are in the source drafts.